Lightspan Adventures Documentation

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Chapter 1

16 Tales 1

The first of the four 16 Tales games published and released by The Lightspan Partnership for the PlayStation 1. Each game consists of four 15-minute video programs various cultures' stories and lore.

16 Tales 1 features a series of four Native American stories, including:

- The Angry Moon
- Coyote and Cottontain & Coyote and the Beaver People
- The Dancing Stars & The Friendly Wolf
- The Fire Bringer & How Saynday Borought the Buffalo to the Indians

Music used throughout: - Sun Valley by David Snell

Story Title	Short Description	Credits
The Angry Moon	A story based on a Native American legend from the Tlingit people in Alaska. Adapted from a legend of the Tlingit Indians of Alaska, this book follows Lupan and Lapowinsa and their adventure to the sky country. Lupowinsa laughs at the moon and is taken as prisoner by the Moon as punishment. Fearing his friends welfare, Lupan makes a ladder of arrows up to sky country. With the help of old grandmother, Lupan is given four gifts to help defeat the Moon and save his friend.	Told by: Ginny Taylor, Producer: K. Hamamura Nelson, Executive Producer and Director: Edmond R Chavanette, Story Editor: Toni Lonehawk Eagleshield, Illustrator: Peggy Ostermann, PhD., Titles and Set: Doug Stiles, Lighting: Ron A. Vanicek, Technical Director: Bill Bolle, Audio: Larraine E. Wilson, Video: Roger Knipp, Videotape: Clarence Pemberton, Camera: John C. Merritt, Martin Miller, Ron A. Vanicek, KLCS Los Angeles Unified School District
Coyote and Cottontail & Coyote and the Beaver People	Based on Navajo stories. Coyote and Cottontail is a story about a wolf who tries to chase a rabbit. Coyote and the Beaver People is a story about a wolf who is skinned by a group of beavers.	Told by: Ginny Taylor, Producer: K. Hamamura Nelson, Executive Producer and Director: Edmond R Chavanette, Story Editor: Toni Lonehawk Eagleshield, Illustrator: Joe Whitecloud Tafoya, Titles and Set: Doug Stiles, Lighting: Ron A. Vanicek, Technical Director: Bill Bolle, Audio: Larraine E. Wilson, Video: Roger Knipp, Videotape: Clarence Pemberton, Camera: John C. Merritt, Martin Miller, Ron A. Vanicek, KLCS Los Angeles Unified School District
The Dancing Stars & The Friendly Wolf	The Dancing Stars is an Iroquois legend. Seven brothers follow a celestial lullaby into the sky, where they encounter the Great Bear and face a choice between home and the stars. The Friendly Wolf is a story that comes from the Dakota people. Siblings Little Cloud and Bright Eyes befriend the Great Wolf during a storm in the mountains. Guided safely home, their encounter fosters a lasting bond between their people and the wolves.	Told by: Dennis Wilkerson, Producer: K. Hamamura Nelson, Executive Producer and Director: Edmond R Chavanette, Story Editor: Toni Lonehawk Eagleshield, The Dancing Stars Illustrators: Holylight & Sam Barcelo, The Friendly Wolf Illustrator: Charles E. Brown, Titles and Set: Doug Stiles, Lighting: Ron A. Vanicek, Technical Director: Bill Bolle, Audio: Larraine E. Wilson, Video: Roger Knipp, Videotape: Clarence Pemberton, Camera: John C. Merritt, Martin Miller, Ron A. Vanicek, KLCS Los Angeles Unified School District
The Fire Bringer & How Saynday Borought the Buffalo to the Indians	The story revolves around two Native American legends: "The Firebringer" from the Paiute tribe and "How the Buffalo Came to the Indians" from the Kiowa tribe. In "The Firebringer," an Indian boy seeks to help his people who are suffering in the cold winter without fire. With the guidance of Coyote, they embark on a dangerous journey to obtain fire from a burning mountain. Despite initial skepticism, they succeed in bringing fire back to their tribe, earning the boy the name "Firebringer." In "How the Buffalo Came to the Indians," Sand Day, observing the suffering of animals due to hunger, devises a plan to discover the source of White Crow's abundant food. Through trickery, Sand Day uncovers a hidden stash of buffalo meat, leading to the release of the buffalo to roam freely and provide sustenance for the Native American tribes. Both stories highlight the importance of survival, resourcefulness, and the interconnectedness between humans and nature in Native American folklore.	Told by: Dennis Wilkerson, Producer: K. Hamamura Nelson, Executive Producer and Director: Edmond R Chavanette, Story Editor: Toni Lonehawk Eagleshield, The Firebringer Illustrators: Holylight & Natche Stan Salazar, How Saynday Borought the Buffalo to the Indians Illustrator: Lavona Thomas, Titles and Set: Doug Stiles, Lighting: Ron A. Vanicek, Technical Director: Bill Bolle, Audio: Larraine E. Wilson, Video: Roger Knipp, Videotape: Clarence Pemberton, Camera: John C. Merritt, Martin Miller, Ron A. Vanicek, KLCS Los Angeles Unified School District,

1.1 Transcriptions

1.1.1 The Angry Moon

Today's story is about "The Angry Moon". It is from the Tlingit Indians of Alaska.

The moon plays an important part in the lives of the Tlingits because most of their food comes from the sea. The moon was considered to be a powerful God to be reckoned with. The Tlingits have a very rich culture and a strong imagination.

In today's story, look for the many beautiful examples of Tlingit designs. You will notice the symbol of an eagle perched on the bow of a boat, on the totems, and on the grandmother's house. This design is based on an old Tlingit legend of "Eagle Woman", who turned herself into an eagle in order to save her children.

The design on grandmother's dress is from a spoon, because you see, the Tlingits made beautiful in-sized spoons out of animal horn. And you will see faces which look like ceremonial masks. In many Indian legends, people are transformed into animals and other beings in order to accomplish their goals. The masks worn in ceremonies which depict these tales are called "transformation masks".

Look for the moon crest on the moon's house, and a whale design on the blankets. In fact, be sure to watch very closely. You'll see designs representing the Northwest Coast Indians throughout the entire story.

But apart from the designs, "The Angry Moon" may be similar to other stories, stories that you've heard before. Tell me if it is. It's now time to listen to the tale of "The Angry Moon".

One very bright summer night, when the moon was full, Lupan and La puinsa were walking in the grassy country that surrounded their village. They were good friends. Tonight, the moon was full and especially bright. It almost seemed to be watching them. Lupan laughed and said, "What a funny face the moon has. How ugly it is."

"Be quiet," said Lupan. "It is not good to speak badly about the moon."

Suddenly, the field was covered in darkness, and a strange, shimmering rainbow appeared from out of the shadows and surrounded La puinsa. She was frightened and cried out for Lupan. He stepped toward her, and the rainbow disappeared, and the darkness disappeared, and La puinsa disappeared. Lupan was all alone in the bright moonlight. He called and called, but there was no La puinsa.

He ran to the top of a hill and cried, "The moon has taken her!" He thought. As his tears dried, he looked up at the sky and saw a brilliant star right beside the Moon. A strange idea came into his mind. "I wonder if I can hit the star..." He took out his bow and arrow and, aiming very carefully at the star, shot at the star. The star disappeared. Strangely, his arrow did not come back. Again and again, Lupan shot his arrows towards the empty space where the star had been. The arrows never, never returned.

Lupan had been shooting arrows all night, and with the first rays of the morning sun, the line of arrows turned into a ladder leading up to the sky. Without knowing why, Lupan picked some branches from a nearby bush and put them in his hair, and then he began to climb the ladder up into the sky. He was afraid. Powerful winds made the ladder spin around. A sudden rainstorm poured down on him, and the ladder became wet and slippery. He hung on tightly and did not fall.

He was still climbing the ladder when night came. Lupan wrapped himself about the ladder and fell asleep. The sunrise of another day shone on Lupan. He had never seen the Sun so bright. The heaviness of his head made him reach up to touch it. He put his hand up to find that the branches in his hair had grown into bushes full of big, sweet berries. He was amazed, but he was also very hungry, so he ate the berries and threw away the branches.

All day long he climbed above the clouds. At nightfall, he reached the top of the ladder. He was very tired, so he lay down and fell asleep. He was awakened by a small voice. "Wake up, I am coming for you. Wake up, my grandmother wishes me to bring you to her. She has been watching you climb here from Earth."

Lupan was very surprised. There was a small boy looking at him, and so Lupan followed the boy over the sky road to the grandmother's house. She was glad to see Lupan and welcomed him. They sat around the fire. The grandmother said, "It is I who helped you on your way to this country. I could tell you were brave and had great need to come up to the sky."

"I have come to find La puinsa," said Lupan

"Yes," said the grandmother, "she has been captured by the moon, who lives near here." They could hear La puinsa's voice wailing in the distance. Lupan wanted to go to her, but the old grandmother told him to eat first to regain his strength. She raised her hand three times, and each time food appeared: first a fish appeared, then a toasted ear of corn, she raised her hand a third time and fresh fruit appeared. Lupan ate hungrily and felt refreshed.

"Now, when you go to the house of the Moon, you must take four things." The grandmother gave him a pine cone and a fisheye, then a rose and a small stone. He was to use these to help him rescue La puinsa. Lupan hurried into the land of the Moon. The closer he came to the moon's house, the louder La puinsa's cries became, and he began to run. Now he could see her up on the roof, caught in the smoke hole with the fire licking at her heels.

He quietly ran to the roof so that the moon could not hear him. La puinsa was so happy to see him, she stopped crying. "Don't stop crying," Lupan whispered. "Cry louder. I don't want the moon to know that you are getting away." So she cried louder as Lupan pulled her from the smoke hole. He put the pine cone in the smoke hole, and it made a crying sound just like La puinsa.

Hand in hand, they started to run. Then the pine cone stopped crying, and the moon became very angry. He had been tricked. He thundered out of his house, chasing after La puinsa and Lupan. He rolled much faster than they could run. Lupan turned and threw the fisheye at him, and where it fell, a large lake appeared. The moon was going so fast, he could not stop and rolled into the lake. He was wet and cold as he rolled out of the lake. He had to roll around the lake, but he was fast. He quickly caught up to Lupan and La puinsa. Lupan threw the rose at the moon, and he became tangled in roses and thorns.

As he came through them, he was very angry. He rolled even faster. When Lupan saw the moon behind them, he threw the stone at the moon, and a huge mountain appeared. It was too high for the moon to climb. It just rolled up and down again.

Tired and breathless, Lupan and La puinsa finally reached the grandmother's house. They were welcomed by the grandmother and the child, and they rested. Then the grandmother said, "Your ladder is waiting for you. You may return to your home on Earth if you wish." They said goodbye and started to climb down the ladder, down through the thick, puffy clouds.

As they reached the Earth, the sun was setting. The rays of the Sun touched the ladder, and it disappeared, leaving a pile of arrows on the ground. The children picked them up and put them in their quivers, then they joyfully ran home. The people of the village were very happy to see them, and for the rest of their lives, people came from far and near to hear their story about "The Angry Moon". The story is still told in the village today.

Did this story remind you of other stories you've heard before? I'll bet it did. "The Angry Moon" may have reminded you of "Hansel and Gretel". You see, stories from all over the world can be very similar. In the American Indian tribes, the storytellers were considered very important people because all of the stories have such deep meanings. The Indians respected the storytellers and loved them.

Look forward to Tlingit and other stories of the Northwest Coast Indians. You can find them in your school or public library. Share a story with a friend so our tales will never end.

1.1.2 Coyote and Cottontail & Coyote and the Beaver People

The Navajo Indians are from the southwestern part of the United States, mainly Arizona and New Mexico. They are excellent farmers and artists, well known for their turquoise and silver jewelry and for their weaving. The beauty of their rugs is known all over the world.

Our first story is a Navajo legend about our good friend "Coyote". "Trotting Coyote", as he is called by the Navajo, is used as an example of how not to be. He tries to cheat and trick and always loses in the end. In our second legend, we will see what happens to Coyote when he meets the beaver people. Listen now to the tales of "Coyote and Cottontail" and "Coyote and the Beaver People".

One day, Trotting Coyote was sitting on a riverbank. He was very hungry and sad because he had not eaten all day. He had not caught a single cottontail or even a tiny mouse. All of a sudden, a cottontail jumped from the bushes where he was hiding and kicked up a great cloud of sand right in Coyote's face. Coyote ran after the cottontail, thinking, "Hmm, what a delicious dinner that cottontail will make."

Coyote was much faster than Cottontail and easily caught him. Just as he was about to take a bite out of the rabbit, the rabbit said, "Stop, don't eat me."

Coyote was so surprised he almost dropped the rabbit. "Rabbits don't talk," he thought. "What a strange rabbit." First, he jumped from a bush where he could have hidden, and now he's talking. Coyote decided to hear what the rabbit had to say.

"You'll be sorry if you eat me," said the Cottontail. "I have no meat on my bones. Why be in such a hurry? I can't escape from you. You are much too big and strong. I'd like to talk to you for a while, but you are squeezing me too hard."

"What do you want to talk about?" said Coyote, as he stopped squeezing a little. The Cottontail thought fast. He was trying to think of a way to escape.

"Uh, let's talk about people. I know all about people."

"I know much more about people than you do," said Coyote, and he squeezed a little harder.

The Cottontail said, "You think you know so much about people? Why, I'll bet you think they carry their weapons on their backs."

"That's right, on their backs," said Coyote.

"And I'll bet you always stay as far away from people as you can. You never really see their weapons. That's why you are wrong. I have seen them carry their weapons in their hands." Cottontail was trying to keep Coyote's mind off his empty stomach. Coyote was squeezing him tightly again.

Cottontail said, "Stop squeezing me so hard, cousin. You have me, and I can't escape. Let me talk for a little while longer, then you may eat me."

Coyote said, "I'll let you talk more about people and their weapons, but make your story very short." Coyote was very annoyed.

Cottontail was trying not to show how scared he was. He sure didn't want to be eaten. "Well, cousin," said Cottontail, "um, what they do is carry a bow and arrow. They hold a bow up, put the arrow at the bowstring, and pull it as hard as they can, and then the arrow flies to its mark."

Coyote said, "No, that's not the way it is. They carry the bow and arrows on their backs and they shoot from over their shoulders."

Cottontail thought to himself, "Here's my chance to escape." "Stop holding me so tightly, and I will show you how it's done," said Cottontail. Coyote loosened his grip as Cottontail raised his arms. Then Cottontail jumped to the ground and ran away as fast as he could.

Coyote chased the rabbit in and out of the bushes, but he never quite caught him. Then Cottontail kicked a thorny yucca plant right into Coyote's mouth. While Coyote was trying to spit out the yucca needles, Cottontail ran into a small cave in the rocks. Coyote couldn't go in after Cottontail because he was too big, so he pretended he wanted to talk.

"Cottontail," said Coyote, "I um, no, you don't really want to talk, you want to eat me."

"If you don't come out, I'm going to smoke you out with cedar bark or sagebrush," said Coyote.

"Oh good, cedar bark and sagebrush are my favorite foods," said Cottontail.

"Hmm, then I'll get some pinion pitch, that will fix you," said Coyote.

Cottontail pretended to be afraid. Coyote piled some rocks in front of the small opening, then he went to get the pitch. Soon he returned and made a fire and placed the pitch on it.

Cottontail pretended to cry, "Oh, please don't blow the smoke on me. I won't be able to breathe."

Coyote blew the smoke into the crack where the rocks were. Cottontail pretended to cough, but he wasn't getting any of the smoke because Coyote was blowing it into the rocks.

Cottontail said, "Blow harder so it will be all over."

Coyote got as close to the fire as he could and blew and blew. He could just taste that rabbit. Suddenly, Cottontail pushed the hot rocks. They fell into the fire and Coyote's face. Cottontail jumped past Coyote and escaped. It took Coyote a long time to get the smoke and dirt from his face. He didn't clean his face very well. He was too busy thinking of the dinner he had lost. That's why to this very day, the coyote has black streaks on his face.

On another day, Trotting Coyote was sitting near a little pool, picking flowers and watching some beaver people playing the hoop and pole game. He had not played the hoop and pole game for a long time. Coyote sat down near the beavers and asked them, "Uh, what is the prize for getting the pole through the hoop?"

A beaver answered, "The loser is skinned by the winner."

Coyote was surprised. "Oh, I wouldn't want to be skinned."

The beavers thought they were rid of Coyote, so they continued playing. One of them threw the pole through the hoop as it was moving. He was the winner, so he began skinning the loser. The loser jumped into the water as soon as he was skinned, swam around a little up and down, in and out, and suddenly grew a new skin.

Coyote thought to himself, "Hmm, since I have magical powers, I'll bet I could grow a new skin too. I think I'll play with them."

An old beaver warned Coyote not to play. He told him to go and play his own games. Coyote begged the beavers to let him play. After much begging, the beavers said yes. They gave Coyote a pole and began rolling the hoop. Coyote threw the pole and won. He didn't know the beaver people had let him win on purpose.

"I knew I would win," boasted Coyote. "I don't want to skin anyone, but I will play another game."

The old beaver said, "If you lose, you will be skinned, and that can hurt if you're not a beaver, so I think you should stop now."

Coyote said, "Now, just grow a new skin like you beavers do."

They let him play again, and he lost. Coyote suddenly decided that he did not want to be skinned, but it was too late. Coyote yelled and howled and sure made a lot of noise.

His skin was finally peeled from him. Coyote ran for the water as soon as they had him peeled. He swam around a little up and down in and out, but nothing happened. He got out of the water and jumped in again, swam around a little up and down and in and out, but still nothing. He didn't get a new skin.

Seeing how upset he was, the beaver people decided to help him. The old beaver said, "Badger has extra skins in his badger hole. Maybe he will give you one. It won't hurt to ask."

Coyote agreed. He didn't care what kind of skin he got as long as he got something to cover his skinless body. So they all went over to the badger hole, and Coyote went inside. When he finally came out, he was wearing a badger skin. To this day, the badger and the coyote have the same kind of skin.

Storytellers were very important people in all Indian tribes. They were respected for their wisdom, and they were loved. Their stories had such deep meanings. In fact, all of the customs and beliefs of the Indian had a story or legend behind them. There were lessons for everyday living woven into interesting stories. The primary concern of all tribes was to live in harmony with the Great Spirit and all that he created.

Go read and enjoy "Legends of the American Indian". You can find them in your school or public library. Share a story with a friend so our tales will never end.

1.1.3 The Dancing Stars & The Friendly Wolf

To the American Indian, all animals and nature—the sky and the Earth, all the creatures that walk, crawl, or fly—were important to everyday life. They were thought of and talked of as though they were real people.

Our first story, "The Dancing Stars," is an Iroquois legend. To the great Iroquois nation in the northeastern part of the United States, the Great Bear sang, and the moon smiled and talked. Everything was a creation of the great spirit.

Our second story, "The Friendly Wolf," comes from the Dakotas, where we find the Plains Indians. Their beliefs were the same as their Iroquois cousins. They respected all animals, and they learned to live with them. The Plains Indians are made up of tribes that we've all heard of: the Sioux, or Lakota; Blackfoot; Cheyenne; Pawnee; the Cree; the Nez Perce; Kiowa; Comanche; Crow; the Ojibwe; the Shoshone; the Arapaho; and the Ute, and a few others. They were hunters, depending mostly on the buffalo for their food, clothing, and the covering for their teepees. They also hunted elk, and antelope, and deer. They ate the wild turnip and wild rice. I suppose they're called wild because they were not planted and cultivated by man. They were planted in the ground by the great spirit for our use.

Now, imagine yourself sitting around a flickering indoor fire in the lodgings of your tribe. It is night, which is the best time for storytelling. The old storyteller is about to begin his stories, and it is cold outside. The soft winter snow is lightly falling. In the distance, you can hear the drumming and the singing. You and the other Indians are waiting for the storyteller to begin.

Now listen to the tales of "The Dancing Stars" and "The Friendly Wolf."

Once long ago, when the sky and the stars and the moon and Mother Earth were just beginning, seven brothers were playing in the forest. They loved to run and dance in the forest, always together, never separated. One evening, just as the sun was going down, the brothers heard someone singing. It was a beautiful, beautiful song coming from some far away place. They danced away, following the sound of the music.

Suddenly, it was night. The little boys looked down and saw the trees in their forest, their people's long houses, all the things they knew about, glowing in the moonlight far below them. They were in the sky, still dancing to the strange and beautiful music. They went up and up and up, and the mysterious song grew louder and even more beautiful. They could hear the words clearly now: "Hunter pursued me and I came to the sky, and now I am lost. But I will watch over you in your warm little cave here in the sky. So sleep, little ones, sleep."

Then, they saw a great black bear. Her belt and necklace were made of shiny white clam shells, and her beautiful tail was made of stars. In fact, stars were twinkling at her toes and her nose. It was the Great Bear who was singing the lullaby. They danced long into the night. At last, they stopped, for they wanted to go home. They asked the moon to show them the way, but the moon smiled gently and said, "You will live here in the sky with the stars and I, for we enjoy your dancing."

Suddenly, the boys no longer felt tired, and they no longer wished to go home. They started to dance again, and the Great Bear sang more sweetly than before. Then, a bright shining star grew around each boy.

The smallest brother heard a voice calling his name. It was the voice of his mother. The little boy ran toward the voice as fast as his feet would go, and the star around him left a bright, shiny trail.

"Don't go, don't go," cried the moon and the stars and his brothers, but the little boy would not listen. He fell past the clouds and the trees, reaching for the earth and the sound of his mother's voice. He saw his mother and reached out to take her hand. Then, he landed. His mother cried when she saw that instead of her son, there was a hole in the ground made by a falling star. She looked up at the sky and called to her other sons, "Stay there, do not come down." She did not want them to become falling stars.

The brothers waved to their mother, for they understood, and they danced on. The mother cried, and her tears fell into the hole where the star had fallen. A little sprout began to grow. It grew faster and faster, taller and taller, up into the sky.

The little brother was now a tree, reaching high into the sky to be with his brothers again. Finally, it reached the Great Bear and the dancing brothers. They were very happy to have their littlest brother back with them. To this day, when you walk through a forest, you will see the pine tree. It is the tallest tree in the forest. And at night, you can see the brothers still dancing to the lullaby of the Great Bear as she sings to her little cubs.

It happened during berry-picking time. This was in the long ago when people and animals lived together and talked to each other. It was the time when the berries were ripe and the camps were set up near the berry bushes, which grew in the valley. The berries were eaten right off the bush.

Little Cloud and his little sister, Bright Eyes, ate all the berries their little stomachs could hold. Little Cloud became tired of berry picking and decided to climb the hills near the valley. He took Bright Eyes with him. They climbed higher and higher to where the grizzly bears and bighorn sheep live. Little Cloud wanted to see the place where the eagles lived, way up on top.

It began to get dark. Little Cloud was afraid. He knew there were mountain lions and wolves in the hills, and the Great Wolf of the mountains. They looked around for a place to stay. It became darker and colder, and Bright Eyes began to cry.

Then, as the owls hooted around them, they saw a small cave. So, they crawled in and went to sleep. Suddenly, Little Cloud was awakened by the loud thunder and cold wind of a fierce storm. In the opening of the cave, he saw the Great Wolf of the mountains. He closed his eyes tightly and prayed that the wolf would not harm them.

As the storm passed, it became quiet. Little Cloud opened his eyes. No wolf. Bright Eyes was still asleep. Maybe he had been dreaming. When the morning came, Little Cloud woke Bright Eyes, and they left the cave quickly. Little Cloud did not tell Bright Eyes of his night visitor, but he knew it wasn't a dream. The tracks in the sand told him so.

As the day went on, they became tired and rested near a stream. The water tasted good. Suddenly, they saw the Great Wolf. Remembering that the wolf did not harm them, Little Cloud said, "Please, Great Wolf of the mountain, we are lost. Help us to return home."

The wolf looked kindly at the children. The Great Wolf reminded Little Cloud of the dogs at camp, with his tongue hanging out and his face smiling. Then, the Great Wolf said, "It was my cave you slept in last night. Have no fear. I will take you home. Stay close to me."

The wolf started off and waited whenever the children fell behind. He would run a little and stop, and run a little and stop. He let Bright Eyes ride on his back when she grew too tired to walk. Then, he led them to berry bushes to eat sweet berries so they wouldn't be hungry. Finally, they reached the top of the hill that they had first climbed. From the hill, they could see their families and friends. They were very, very happy. They wanted the wolf to stay with them, but the Great Wolf refused. He could not go closer to the camp because there were dogs there.

"Anyway, I would not be happy living in a camp. I am a wanderer. I go with my wolf friends to many places. Do not be sad. I will always remember you, and you will hear my call in the early night and think of me."

As the children came down to the camp, the men raced on their horses to meet them. They picked them up and joyfully rode into camp. There was much excitement and happiness at their return. When the people heard Little Cloud's story of how the wolf had saved them, they went to the top of the hill and thanked him. They brought him beautiful gifts and food. The chiefs sat in a circle and smoked the pipe of peace.

It was the sign of friendship forever between the Indians and the wolves. That friendship still lasts.

Wherever the Indians traveled, hunted, laughed, or prayed, it was a tribal affair. They were great believers in togetherness, and that togetherness always included the animals. The storytellers were very important people in all tribes. They were respected for their wisdom, and they were greatly loved. Their stories had deep meanings, for all of the customs and beliefs of the Indians had a story or a legend behind them. Many of these stories are in your school and public library. Go read, enjoy the stories of the American Indian, and share a story with a friend so our tales will never end.

1.1.4 The Fire Bringer & How Saynday Borought the Buffalo to the Indians

Just as you have favorite fairy tales and stories, the Paiute Indians have long ago loved to hear the old Legends told over and over again.

The Peyote Indians lived mainly in Utah. According to the Paiutes, it was Coyote who taught mankind how to survive on the earth.

Our first story, "The Firebringer," will see how Coyote taught the Indians about fire. The second story is a Kiowa Legend called "How Saynday Borought the Buffalo to the Indians." The Kiowa Indians are Plains Indians. They have lived on the Southern Plains around Oklahoma and Kansas for as long as time itself. They hunted the buffalo. Saynday, who brought many things to the Kiowa, was responsible. Now, listen to the tales of the Firebringer and how Saynday brought the Buffalo to the Indians.

Long ago, in the time of the beginning when animals and humans talked to each other and lived together, there was an Indian boy called the Firebringer. He was of the Paiute Tribe with shiny dark skin and long black hair. He loved to run with a coyote, who was the friend and counselor of his people. They would hunt together in the summer; the boy caught fish with his hands while the women dug delicious roots. In the summer, times were good. Now the winter was not so good. The people were cold and unhappy; this was before the tribes knew about fire.

The boy spoke to the coyote, asking his advice. "How can we help my people? They cannot keep warm in this cold. What can we do?"

The coyote thought, and then he said, "You and I will go to the burning mountain and bring back fire. It will be dangerous, but it is the only way. Gather a hundred strong men and women who are your best runners."

The boy went to gather the runners, but they paid no attention to him; they didn't know what fire was. But the boy continued to talk about the fire, and as the people got colder and colder, one by one, they joined him. Soon, he had his hundred runners.

The coyote explained exactly what was to be done. First in front would be the coyote and the boy; then the fastest runners would follow them, and the slowest would be last.

They went toward the west over the high snow-covered mountains, then through dark windy forests. The runners grew afraid. Coyote said to them, "We will rest here. In the morning, one of you will stay here until the fire comes. You will know the fire because it is red like a rose, but it is not a rose. When you see the fire, you will know it."

In the morning, they headed west, leaving one man to wait for the fire. The people wondered if the fire was an animal or an enemy of some kind.

Coyote explained, "Fire can be an enemy or friend; it can hurt, but it can also help and serve us. If it is covered with rocks and sticks, it can be used to warm the people." The last runner was left to wait for the fire; coyote and the boy continued on to the burning mountain. It was very high with smoke and fire pouring out of its top. At night, the fire spirits danced on the mountaintop. Coyote made himself look thin and weak and unimportant and went up the mountain. The fire spirit saw him but ignored him because he looked harmless.

As the fire spirits began to dance, coyote stole a burning stick and ran down the mountain. The fire spirit saw him running with a fire and began to chase him. Coyote was tired and breathing hard when the boy took the burning stick from his friend and ran with the fire spirits fast behind him.

The boy ran as fast as he could until he came to the runner they had left behind. This runner took the burning stick and ran on. The stick was passed from runner to runner; the fire spirits chased each runner until they were stopped by the snowy mountains. The swift runners continued through the day and night until they came to the land of the Paiute. They surrounded the fire with rocks and put sticks on it and were warmed by it, just as coyote had told them.

From that time on, the boy was called Firebringer. The name Firebringer was passed on to the coyote because he had earned the name.

To this very day, coyote's fur is thin and yellow, as if burned along his sides, perhaps because of the fire stick he carried in his mouth whose flames licked at his sights as he ran down the burning mountain.

Saynday was coming along, and he saw all the animals singing and dancing, and he asked them what they were doing. Owl and Dragonfly told him it was a Sundance to show the Sun how much they loved it. Coyote said, "We are having a fine time, but we are hungry; we have no food."

Fox said, "We are all getting weak because we have no food."

Saynday felt very sorry for the animals as they watched the dancing. He thought of the white crow. "Why is the crow so fat, and his feathers so smooth? He must have plenty of food. Where does he get his food?" Nobody knew.

Now, White Crow always carried a bow and some arrows in a special case, and he never put it down. Saynday decided the answer to White Crow's food must be in the case. Saynday wondered how he could get the case; then he thought of a plan.

He told Fox and Coyote, and Owl and Dragonfly, to watch White Crow when he left the dancing grounds to find out where he lived. They agreed.

Saynday and his friends started to flatter White Crow. "Why aren't you singing? You have such a beautiful voice." White Crow was very pleased to help the singers. Saiyan Day offered to hold the bow and arrow case for White Crow. As White Crow began singing and drumming, all the animals crowded around him, so he couldn't see Saynday. Saynday took the bow and arrows out of the case and laid them down. He reached way into the case and pulled out a piece of meat. Buffalo meat.

He thought to himself, "I have never tasted anything so delicious. This would be good for the Indians." The singing finished, and Saynday gave White Crow his case. As White Crow flew away, Fox and Coyote, and Owl and Dragonfly, all watched; he flew way up and over the nearby hill. Saynday told his friends he would stay behind and think of some way to find out where the buffalo meat was hidden.

He hid near a bush and changed himself into a little puppy. He wanted White Crow's little daughter to find him. Then the little daughter came walking along and saw the puppy. The puppy began licking her ankles, and she picked him up; she wanted to keep him.

But when she took him home, White Crow didn't like him. "I never saw a puppy with a mustache before." Saiyan Day had forgotten to change his mustache. White Crow's little daughter started to cry. So, he agreed she could keep the puppy if she did not take him near the meat.

Saynday ate well that night: Buffalo scraps. The next day, White Crow and his wife had to leave. He said to his daughter, "Remember, don't take the puppy near the meat; that is our secret." Then he and his wife left. Soon, the little White Crow got tired of playing with the puppy. "I'm going to show you our secret place where we keep our meat," Saynday pretended he wasn't interested. The little girl picked him up and took him over to a big deep hole that had been covered with a rock.

Down in the hole were all the Buffaloes in the world, father Buffaloes, mother Buffaloes, and baby Buffaloes. "Indian people should have this food to share; they will never be hungry again." He started barking and jumped down among the Buffaloes. The Buffaloes rushed out of the hole into the sunshine; they sounded like thunder as they ran. White Crow heard the thunder and flew back home as fast as he could; he knew it was the Buffaloes.

As the last Buffalo came up out of the hole, Saynday came out and turned back into himself. He turned to the buffaloes. "You will live here in this country wherever the grass shall grow, to the east, to the west, to the north, and to the south; you will roam; you will be the food for the people of this country."

The Buffalo listened to Saiyan Day; they wandered and spread out over the plains, for they fed and clothed the people. How the Buffalo came to the Indians.

The Indians came to depend on buffalo meat for a large part of their diet and on its skin for clothing, shelter, and many other uses. In winter, the warm skin was used for robes and blankets; no part of the Buffalo was wasted. Without this magnificent animal, the Kiowa as well as other Plains tribes possibly would have died out. Today, you have heard just two stories of the American Indian; you can find many more in your school or public libraries. Go read and enjoy the stories of the American Indian, and share a story with a friend so our tales will never end.

Figure 1.1: 16 Tales 1 Screenshot

Chapter 2

16 Tales 2

2.1 Information

The second of the four 16 Tales games published and released by The Lightspan Partnership for the PlayStation 1. Each game consists of four 15-minute video programs various cultures' stories and lore.

16 Tales 2 features a series of four Native American stories, including:

- The Blind Man's Daughter
- Jose and the Croocodile
- Ma Liang and the Magic Brush
- The Tale of Urashima Taro

Music used throughout: - Sun Valley by David Snell

Story Title	**Short Description**	**Credits**
The Blind Man's Daughter	This story comes from Korea. The story revolves around Shim Cheong, a dutiful daughter living with her blind father. To restore her father's sight, she sacrifices herself to a river dragon in exchange for 300 bags of rice that could cure him. Shim Cheong is taken to the dragon's palace where she lives in comfort. Eventually, she emerges from a lotus blossom, catches the attention of the king, and becomes his wife. Despite her newfound happiness, Shim Cheong's thoughts remain with her father, whom she eventually finds and restores his sight. The story highlights Shim Cheong's selflessness, sacrifice, and eventual reward for her devotion to her father.	Told by: Hyun-Oak Alan Kim, Producer: K. Hamamura Nelson, Executive Producer and Director: Edmond R. Chavanette, Story Editor: Suzie Kim Oh, Illustrator: Hee Do Cho, Titles and Set: Doug Stiles, Lighting: Ron A. Vanicek, Technical Director: Bill Bolle, Audio: Larraine E. Wilson, Video: Roger Knipp, Videotape: Clarence Pemberton, Camera: John C. Merritt, Martin Miller, Ron A. Vanicek, KLCS Los Angeles Unified School District
Jose and the Croocodile	This story comes from the Philippines. The story "Jose and the Crocodile" tells of a young boy named Jose who encounters a crocodile trapped in a net while gathering coconuts. Despite the crocodile's plea for help, Jose frees him, hoping for a reward. However, the crocodile betrays Jose and tries to eat him, forcing Jose to seek help from passing objects in the river. Each object refuses to help, citing ingratitude from humans. Finally, a monkey comes to Jose's rescue, allowing him to escape the crocodile's grasp. In gratitude, Jose promises to plant banana trees for the monkey's family. This story highlights themes of gratitude, betrayal, and unexpected kindness, typical of Filipino folktales.	Told by: Patricia Payuyo, Producer: K. Hamamura Nelson, Executive Producer and Director: Edmond R. Chavanette, Story Editor: Rolando A. Santos, PhD., Illustrator: Don M. Dumandan, Titles and Set: Doug Stiles, Lighting: Ron A. Vanicek, Technical Director: Bill Bolle, Audio: Larraine E. Wilson, Video: Roger Knipp, Videotape: Clarence Pemberton, Camera: John C. Merritt, Martin Miller, Ron A. Vanicek, KLCS Los Angeles Unified School District
Ma Liang and the Magic Brush	This story comes from China. The story tells of a poor peasant boy named Ma Liang who dreams of painting but cannot afford brushes. Through hard work and dedication, he practices drawing with makeshift tools until one day, a wizard appears and gifts him a magic brush. With this brush, anything he paints becomes real. Ma Liang uses his brush to help his village by painting clothes, animals, and food for the needy. However, when the greedy Emperor hears of Ma Liang's brush, he seeks to use it for his own gain. Ma Liang outwits the Emperor and continues to use his brush for good, traveling across China to help those in need. The story showcases themes of kindness, perseverance, and the power of creativity.	Told by: Jeanne Joe, Producer: K. Hamamura Nelson, Executive Producer and Director: Edmond R. Chavanette, Story Editor: Janna R. Wong, Illustrations: Castelar Elementary School, Titles and Set: Doug Stiles, Lighting: Ron A. Vanicek, Technical Director: Bill Bolle, Audio: Larraine E. Wilson, Video: Roger Knipp, Videotape: Clarence Pemberton, Camera: John C. Merritt, Martin Miller, Ron A. Vanicek, KLCS Los Angeles Unified School District
The Tale of Urashima Taro	This storm comes from Japan. "The Tale of Urashima Taro" is a cherished Japanese folk tale that recounts the story of a young fisherman named Urashima Taro. Living in a coastal village with his elderly parents, Taro is known for his kindness and skill as a fisherman. One day, after a disappointing catch, he rescues a sea turtle from children's torment. In gratitude, the turtle, who is actually a princess in disguise, takes Taro to the Dragon Palace under the sea. There, he experiences incredible beauty, hospitality, and enchantment, but eventually feels homesick. Despite the princess's pleas, Taro decides to return home. Before leaving, she gives him a mysterious lacquered box with strict instructions not to open it. Upon his return to the village, Taro finds everything changed and realizes that centuries have passed. Feeling lost and lonely, he finally opens the box, which releases a mist that ages him instantly. The story explores themes of kindness, the passage of time, and the consequences of curiosity. It's one of many beloved folk tales from Japan, sharing valuable lessons and captivating readers with its enchanting narrative.	Told by: David Hirokane, Producer: K. Hamamura Nelson, Executive Producer and Director: Edmond R. Chavanette, Story Editor: Peggy Okeya, Illustrations: Kellene Adachi Coy, Titles and Set: Doug Stiles, Lighting: Ron A. Vanicek, Technical Director: Bill Bolle, Audio: Larraine E. Wilson, Video: Roger Knipp, Videotape: Clarence Pemberton, Camera: John C. Merritt, Martin Miller, Ron A. Vanicek, KLCS Los Angeles Unified School District,

2.2 Transcriptions

2.2.1 The Blind Man's Daughter

Our story today comes from Korea, a country in eastern Asia. In today's story about the blind man's daughter, you will notice that the girl's name is Shim Cheong. "Chun" is her first name, like Jenny or Maria, and "Shim" is her family name. As in many Asian cultures, the family name is set first. So, if your name is John Smith in Korea, you would be called Smith John. Listen now to the tale of "The Blind Man's daughter".

Five hundred years ago, maybe more, there lived in a certain village a girl named Shim Cheong. Her mother had died long ago, and now her father was going blind. Shim Cheong was very beautiful. Her face was smooth and white, her hair was shiny and black. She was very good and honest, and she had never been sick. It was as if nothing could harm her. She guided her father when he had to work, but his blindness kept him from work, and little by little, all they owned had to be sold to keep them alive.

The old man, Shim, became a beggar. He felt ashamed that his daughter had to go with him to beg for coins. One day, he went out alone. He tripped and fell into a ditch. He tried to climb out, but he couldn't. Then, a strong hand reached out and lifted him up, and a voice spoke to him, "Give me 300 bags of rice for the temple, old man, and in time, you shall have your eyes once again." It was the voice of a priest from the temple, and the old man's heart filled with hope.

That evening, he told his daughter what had happened. But as he told her, his hope went away, and he got very, very sad. "I go, I go, there is no way for beggars like us to get so much rice." That night, as Shim Cheong drifted off to sleep, she sighed, "What to do, what to do?"

"As I say," someone answered in a dream. A dead mother told her how to get the rice and help her father see again. The next morning, Shim Cheong awoke early. She dressed in a long grey gown and a big hat. Then, she walked to the house of a very rich merchant. Now, this merchant owned many, many boats. They brought rice to faraway China. But there was a river dragon who would not let the boats go through. He would spit water and lash the waves with his tail. It was too dangerous for boats to sail.

"What must I give you? What must I do so my boats may go through?" said the merchant to the dragon.

"You must bring me a beautiful girl," the dragon answered.

And so, the merchant spread the news far and wide. He'd offer 300 bags of rice to the girl who would give herself to the dragon. Shim Cheong told the merchant that she wished to offer herself to the dragon.

"You do not deserve to die. You are a good daughter and you are dutiful to your father," but there was no other way for Shim Cheong to get the rice. So, the bargain was made.

The next day, Shim Cheong watched the horses carry the bags of rice to the priest's temple. Then, she bowed before the tomb of her mother and prayed, "O heavenly spirits, care for my father until he is cured." And she spoke to her neighbors, "All kind neighbors, care for my father until he's cured." Then, she set forth to keep her part of the bargain.

She wore a beautiful gown of green and red with jewels and golden ribbons in her hair. Her beauty shone brighter than the sun in the eastern sky. Soon, they came to the place in the river where the dragon lashed his huge tail. It was time to sacrifice Shim Cheong to the dragon. The merchant wanted to save her.

"O river dragon, do not take this girl," but the river dragon demanded the beautiful girl. So, Shim Cheong said goodbye to the merchant. She closed her eyes and jumped off the sides of the boat and disappeared into the water.

Instantly, the river became calm and quiet like a garden pool. Shim Cheong floated through the water. Pearls flashed before her eyes. Big, rainbow-colored fish danced by, and sea plants tickled her nose as she brushed past them. At last, she arrived at the palace of the dragon.

"Kind sir, I am the daughter of the blind beggar, Shim. I'm not worthy to come before one so important as you," the river dragon spoke.

"A message has come to us from Hananim, the emperor of heaven and earth. You shall be rewarded for your goodness to your blind father," then, sea maidens dressed Shim Cheong in the finest clothes. They gave her the softest sleeping mats and the richest food.

In this life of comfort and ease, Shim Cheong grew more beautiful than ever. Then one day, the maidens took her to a giant lotus blossom that lay on the river bottom, and they put her right in it. It was so large that it covered her completely.

"Goodbye, Shim Cheong," said the river dragon.

"Goodbye," Shim Cheong answered back, and soon she felt herself rising like a bubble up through the water. When she reached the top, she was floating next to the boat of the rice merchant. But the rice merchant did not see her. All he saw was the blossom.

"Never in heaven or on earth was there such a lotus flower as this," said the merchant. "Let us take it to the king." The merchant presented the flower to the king. The king was delighted. No one else in all the world had such a blossom. Every day, he admired it floating in the garden pool.

All day long, Shim Cheong hid inside the giant flower. Then one night, as she ventured out of the blossom, the king discovered her. She ran to hide, but the blossom had disappeared. The king looked at her, "Can this be a spirit? She's so beautiful." He called his wise men. On the day the lotus flower was brought to the king, a bright new star had appeared in the sky.

"That's a good sign," and so he made Shim Cheong his wife. Shim Cheong was happy in her life as a queen, but some days she would think of her poor father, "Here I have all I want, but my father's eyes are closed to the world."

One day, the king saw her weeping, "Go, my husband," Shim Cheong said to the king. "I have had a dream about a blind man. It makes me cry. I should like to do something for all the blind people in the kingdom." So, a message was sent to all the blind beggars of the kingdom to invite them to a feast in the king's courtyard.

One day, two days, and three days passed. Beggars came from far and near to eat rice and kimchi. Queen Cheong watched every day, hoping the next person would be her father. The end of the feast came, and still no father. Then one day, there was a noise in the courtyard. A latecomer was being pushed about by the servants.

"Father, father, it is my dear father! Let him stay!" She ordered her servants to dress him in new clothing and bring him to her chamber.

"What wonder is this?" said the old man, Shim, when he heard his daughter's voice. "Do apricots bloom in the snow? Do horses have horns? Do dead men come to life? How can I be sure you are truly Chung?" And he rubbed his eyes. Suddenly, just as the temple priest had promised, the old man's sight returned.

"Oh, my goodness, you are beautiful!" he said. The king welcomed the Shim Cheong's father into the palace, and Queen Cheong was happy all day long. Her father could see again. This was the heavenly reward to the dutiful daughter of the blind beggar, Shim.

The story of the blind man's daghter, Shim Cheong, is just one of the many folk tales from Korea. You can find others in your school or public library: stories such as "The Man Who Lived a Thousand Years" and A Korean Cinderella, "Kongjwi and Patjwi". Read and enjoy the folk tales from Korea and from all over the world. Share a story with a friend, so our tales will never end.

2.2.2 Jose and the Crocodile

Long ago, the early people of the Philippines made up stories to tell their children. These folktales were the textbooks of their day. They served to preserve the history and traditions of the people. They told about events that had happened and also tried to explain the interesting things in nature that they saw about them. In a land of volcanoes, earthquakes, and violent storms, there was a lot to try to explain.

Mountains erupted, and sometimes the earth shook beneath their feet, and new islands rose unexpectedly from the sea. The people were always surrounded by nature, so they were often puzzled by some of the oddities they saw. What was this fish with no bones or scales and looked like a blob of jelly? What made insects glow in the dark? Where did the eagle come from and the crocodile? They made up a story for everything. Talking animals are found as characters in folktales everywhere, and as is proper in a tropical country, it is a quick-thinking monkey who is a hero of today's story. "Jose and the Crocodile", and its characters, setting, and topic is a typical Filipino story. This story may be like some stories you have heard before. Tell me if it is. Now listen to this tale of "Jose and the Crocodile".

Jose lived with his family in a little village next to a river. Jose's father raised coconuts, bananas, and other fruits and vegetables. One day, his mother asked, "Jose, will you please gather some coconuts? I need them for cooking and feeding the hogs, and your father would like to sell some at the market.

"Yes, mother, right away," Jose answered.

Jose hitched the water buffalo to a sled. He took his sharp bolo and strapped it to his waist. He climbed on the water buffalo and started looking for fallen coconuts. Jose was too small to climb the tall coconut trees, so he gathered ones that had fallen off the trees. There were not too many on the ground near the house that day, so he wandered farther and farther away. It was hard work, and Jose traveled far. The air was hot and humid. Jose and the water buffalo became very tired and thirsty, so they went to the river for a drink and a quick swim in the cool water.

While Jose was splashing water on the water buffalo, he heard a groan coming from far away. It sounded like a cry of some animal in pain. Jose became worried. He jumped on the water buffalo and rode towards the sound. The groans became louder and louder as they rode. Soon, Jose saw a big rope hanging from a branch of a large tree. At the end of the rope was a net, and in the net, a big crocodile was fighting to get out.

"Hmm, crocodile catchers were here again," thought Jose to himself. "They will make shoes and belts and bags out of this poor crocodile's skin."

"Little boy, please help me. I have a wife and children," begged the crocodile with big tears in his eyes. "If you set me free, I will give you a large gold ring," promised the crocodile.

Jose felt sorry for the crocodile and decided to help him. Besides, he thought, "When I get the gold ring, father can sell it, and we won't have to work as hard anymore."

He took his bolo from its wooden sheath and stood on the water buffalo, and after several blows, cut the rope. Jose climbed off the buffalo and, cutting it into pieces, the crocodile slid through the net. He was free again. "Now that I have set you free, may I have the gold ring you promised me?"

"The beautiful gold ring is in my house on the river. Up on my back, and we will go and get it, then you will be rich," Jose did just as he was told.

Quietly, the crocodile slid down the bank into the river. Jose held tightly to the crocodile's slippery back. "Foolish child, huh? He has no idea that I want to eat him. I'm very hungry, and he will make a tasty meal."

As the water got deeper and deeper, Jose asked, "How much farther is your home? Are we close to it now?"

The crocodile turned his snout towards Jose and said, "Oh, I just remembered the ring is in my stomach. I'll have to swallow you so you can get it yourself."

As Jose looked at the large teeth and the crocodile's huge mouth, he became frightened. "Oh no, Mr. Crocodile, please don't swallow me. I shall never get out of your stomach alive. Let me go, please let me go. I don't even want your ring anymore," Jose begged and begged.

The crocodile decided to play a game with Jose. "All right, my boy, you know as much as you helped set me free, I will give you a chance to be free. You must ask the next three things that float down the river whether or not I should eat you. If they say no, then I will set you free, but if they say yes, I will eat you up."

Jose had no choice. "That sounds fair enough."

The first thing they saw floating down the river was an upside-down banca, which is a dugout canoe. "Banca, banca, please help me."

"What can I do for you, young man?" that's the banca.

"Do you think it is fair for this crocodile to eat me up after I set him free from the trappers' net?"

"Well, son, let me tell you, when I was a new banca, my owner was very proud of me. He sailed me up and down the river, catching fish. I carried vegetables, rice, chickens, and even his family. But as I grew older, I acquired some leaks, so my owner decided to build another banca and sent me floating down the river. I'm slowly rotting away. People are not very grateful.

Why should Mr. Crocodile be grateful? If I were he, I would eat you up." And with that, the banca floated past Jose and the crocodile.

Next came a torn basket with moss growing on its sides. "Basket, basket, please help me. Please tell the crocodile he shouldn't eat me after I set him free from the trappers' net."

The basket creaked and said, "Huh, people wish others to be grateful, but they themselves never show gratitude. Why, when I was new, my owners took me to the market and filled me with vegetables and fruits. Yes, I was very useful, but the loads got so heavy that after a few months, I started falling apart. Then my master's wife threw me away. Here I am floating all day and all night, just rotting away. Crocodile, eat that boy up, teach people a lesson on thankfulness." Jose was getting sadder and sadder. He cried for his mother, and he cried for his father.

Then a battered old hat came floating by. "Hat, hat, please help me. Please tell the crocodile not to eat me. I set him free from the trappers' net, and now he wants to eat me. Please tell the crocodile it's not fair."

The hat left, "Thankfulness, my boy, talk about thankfulness. I remember when I was new, my master wore me proudly. I kept him cool when the Sun was hot and dry when it rained. Then I grew old and shaggy, and he threw me into the river, so here I am just floating in this river all day and all night, and I am rotting away. Crocodile, eat him up, you should not be thankful to people who do not know how to be thankful themselves."

The crocodile was happy. At last, he was going to have his meal. Jose cried and cried. He cried so loudly that a monkey sitting on a tree by the river heard his cries. The monkey chattered and ran up and down a branch. "Oh, Mr. Crocodile, Mr. Crocodile, give me a ride, please. I'd like to float down the river too," said the monkey.

"Why certainly, my dear friend, we will be happy to give you a ride," said the crocodile. "Huh, what a great meal I shall have today, a tasty boy and a monkey."

"Mr. Crocodile, come closer to the riverbank so I can jump on your back. Come closer, closer." The crocodile came closer and closer. Then suddenly, the monkey threw a vine to Jose. Jose cut the vine and lifted himself off the crocodile's back and onto the tree. The crocodile snapped his jaws and lashed his long tail, just inches from Jose's feet, but Jose was safe on the tree.

"Thank you, oh thank you, how can I ever repay you for saving my life?" begged Jose.

"Easily," said the monkey. "What I love most is bananas. Ask your father to plant enough banana trees to feed both your family and my family. That will be enough payment," said the monkey.

"All right, I will," said Jose.

Jose climbed down the tree, and the monkey jumped on his shoulder. Then they both ran to tell the story to Jose's family, and from that day on, Jose and the monkey became very close friends.

"Jose and the Crocodile" is just one of many stories from the Philippines. You can find others in your school or public libraries. Stories like "Dr. Omar and the Fairy" and "Princess Merraine the Huntress" and the story of the absent-minded King. Read and enjoy the stories from the Philippines and from all over the world. Share a story with a friend so our tales will never end.

2.2.3 Ma Liang and the Magic Brush

Neih hou ma. Hello, come sit beside me, for I'm going to tell you a story from China.

China is a very old, old country. In fact, it's the world's oldest living civilization. The Chinese people call their country "Zhongguo", which means "middle country". Today, most of the people live in small villages and work together in communes, but China also has several of the world's largest cities. The Chinese people are very proud of their nation, its long history, and its influence on other countries. The Chinese were the first to develop the compass, gunpowder, paper, porcelain, printing, and silk cloth. The Chinese language has many dialects. Written Chinese uses characters instead of an alphabet. Each character stands for a complete idea, thing, or sound. It's a very difficult language to learn because there are more than 40,000 characters.

Our story today is an old favorite. Many Chinese stories are about gods, spirits, wizards, and even animals such as the dragon, who all have special powers. In today's story, a wizard brings happiness to a young village boy named Ma Liang. So come sit beside me, and I'm going to tell you the story of "Ma Liang Young and a Magic Brush".

A long time ago, in a small village in China, there lived a poor young peasant boy named Ma Liang. Ma Liang's parents died when he was a small child, so he couldn't go to school like the other children in the village. Instead, he worked all day, gathering firewood or pulling weeds for the people of the town. Every morning, Ma Liang stopped to watch the children in the schoolyard make pictures with brushes and paint. The schoolmaster showed them how to draw green trees and blue birds and red roosters. Ma Liang was fascinated by the graceful strokes of their brushes and dreamed of all the beautiful pictures he would paint if he owned a brush. But his chores earned him only enough money for food and clothes, so of course, he could not afford to buy brushes and paint. After the painting lesson was over, the children went back inside the schoolhouse, and Ma Liang went slowly back to his chores with a frown on his face and a dream in his heart.

One day, as Ma Liang watched the children painting, he timidly approached the schoolmaster. "Excuse me, might I have an old brush so that I too can paint lovely pictures?"

"Hmm, so you think you would like to paint, eh?" said the schoolmaster. "You are just a poor peasant. Go back to your chores and do not come back into the school yard again."

Ma Liang was sad but not discouraged. "Why shouldn't I learn to paint even though I am poor?" he said to himself. "I will learn even if I do not have a brush. I will draw the things I see." At the end of the day, when he finished his chores, Ma Liang looked carefully at everything around him and drew pictures wherever he could. With a stick, he drew trees and birds on the soft ground, and with his fingers, he drew turtles on the sand. When he went back to his little hut, Ma Liang drew pictures on the walls with a piece of burnt firewood. Long into the night, he drew picture after picture. By morning, he had covered the walls with drawings of everything he could think of. Ma Liang practiced his drawing every day. Soon the birds he drew looked just like the birds in the trees. The fish he drew looked just like the fish in the river. He became so skillful that the people of his village marveled at his pictures. They would gather around him when he drew his pictures in the dirt, but Ma Liang was still sad that he did not have his own brush. Every night before he went to bed, he closed his eyes and wished for one.

One night, in a cloud of smoke and a flash of light, an old wizard appeared. The old man had watched Ma Liang every day as he drew his pictures and made the village people happy. "Ma Liang," he said in a creaky voice, "You have worked very hard, and now you have earned a brush, but use it wisely, for it has great powers." And then with another cloud of smoke and a flash of light, the old man vanished.

The next morning, Ma Liang awoke and thought about his strange dream. He looked down, and in his hands was a golden brush. He blinked to see if he was still dreaming, but the brush was really there. He jumped out of bed and went to the wall of his hut. There he drew a beautiful bird with his new brush. Then, right before his eyes, the bird became real. Ma Liang watched with wonder as the bird flapped its wings and flew off the wall. It flew out of Ma Liang's window to a tree outside, where it sang sweetly for the village people. "That's amazing," thought Ma Liang.

Then Ma Liang took his brush and scurried outside to a nearby stream, and on a rock, he painted a toad, and just as he finished, the toad jumped off the rock and into the stream with a splash. The young boy stopped and looked again at his wonderful brush. It was magic. Everything he painted became real.

Now, instead of gathering firewood and pulling weeds, Ma Liang went from hut to hut to the poor people of his village and asked them, "What is it that you want most of all? I will paint it for you." Some said they needed clothing for their children, so Ma Liang painted clothing. A poor farmer asked for a buffalo to pull his plow, so Ma Liang painted him a strong, healthy buffalo, and he painted food for the women to cook. All of the people in the village were very grateful and very happy.

It was not long before the Emperor heard about this young artist who was spreading good fortune throughout the village. But the Emperor was a mean and greedy man. All he wanted was more and more gold for his kingdom. He wanted Ma Liang's brush for the wealth it could bring him. "Bring me the boy Ma Liang," he commanded, "so that I might have the magic brush." So the Emperor's soldiers marched to the small village to find Ma Liang. They told him of the Emperor's wishes, but Ma Liang did not want to go, so the soldiers arrested Ma Liang and carried him back to the Emperor's castle.

Ma Liang was brought before the Emperor. "So you're the boy who paints pictures for the village people. If this is so, paint me a golden dragon," demanded the Emperor. Ma Liang pretended he did not understand. He went to the wall and, instead of painting a golden dragon, he painted a green frog that leapt off the wall and landed right in the emperor's bowl of rice. Then the Emperor ordered Ma Liang to paint him a bar of gold. Instead, Ma Liang drew a large yellow serpent. It attacked the Emperor and had to be killed by the soldiers. The emperor was furious and grabbed the magic brush. He ordered Ma Liang thrown into the dungeon.

Then the Emperor called for the court painter. He handed him Ma Liang's brush and said, "Paint me a great tree with leaves of gold coins that will fall like rain when I shake the branches. Do it at once." The court painter did as he was told. When he finished, there was a beautiful picture of a tree on the wall with many gold coins on its branches, but when the Emperor rushed to the tree to shake the branches, he ran right into the wall and bumped his head on it. The tree was not real; it was only a picture. Now the Emperor realized that the brush had magical powers only when Ma Liang was the painter. He ordered his soldiers to bring the boy from the dungeon.

When Ma Liang appeared, the greedy Emperor tried to make friends with him and spoke to him kindly. "Here is your magic brush. I know I cannot use it to paint the things I want, but if you will stay in my palace and paint pictures for me, I will make you very rich." Ma Liang pretended to agree, so the Emperor handed Ma Liang the brush. "Now paint me a mountain of pure gold," he said. Ma Liang painted the mountain, but he painted it behind a great and beautiful blue sea. "Beautiful, beautiful," cried the Emperor. "Now paint me a ship so that I can sail to my mountain and bring back the gold." In a twinkling, Ma Liang painted a fine ship worthy of an emperor. The emperor and his soldiers quickly climbed aboard and set sail for the mountain, but since there was no wind, the ship moved very slowly. So the Emperor called out, "Too slow, too slow, paint a wind to speed us along." Again, Ma Liang did as he was told, and he painted a huge gust of wind to move the Emperor's ship. The wind tore at the sails, and great waves pounded the ship. "Too much," cried the Emperor angrily, "you will sink us!" But Ma Liang could not hear the Emperor's cries. The storm he had painted was too loud. The wind howled, and the waves crashed about the wooden ship. Then with a great crack, it split in two and sank into the stormy waters.

Ma Liang walked slowly away from the palace. Never again was he forced to paint for evil purposes. Instead, he traveled across the lands of China from one small village to another and painted for the poor with his magic brush.

China has more than 3,000 years of recorded history, and its myths, legends, folktales, and proverbs date from ancient times. China is a very large country. There are different stories told in different parts of China, and the stories tell of the way of life of the people from different areas. There are hundreds of stories from China, stories like "The King of the Monkeys" and the story of "The First Kite". You can find them in your school or public libraries. Read and enjoy the tales of China and stories from all over the world. Share a story with a friend so our tales will never end.

2.2.4 The Tale of Urashima Taro

The tale of "Urashima Taro" is one of Japan's oldest and most treasured folktales. The story has been passed from one generation to another and is still an old favorite to the Japanese people. They try to combine the best of Western and Japanese ways of life. They eat both Japanese and Western foods, read both Japanese and Western books, and wear both Japanese and Western clothes. The people love beauty, and many take vacation trips to admire the beautiful trees and flowers of their country. They often travel in large groups, and sometimes a whole school class takes an overnight trip. Japanese children go to school and study many of the same subjects as students in the United States, but more time is spent on reading and writing because the language is so difficult.

The Japanese borrowed the Chinese system of writing as well as many Chinese words. The writing includes symbols which were once picture words. Long ago, when Japanese children asked questions, many times the elders would tell a story to explain the answer. The children often asked about the life of a prince or a princess. When they asked why they too could not live like royalty, their parents answered by telling them the story of "Urashima Taro", and they began by saying, "Mukashi mukashi..."

Long, long ago, there lived a young fisherman named Urashima Taro. He lived with his old parents in a small village on the coast of Japan. Taro's father had been a fisherman before him and had taught him the skill and knowledge of fishing, but now, since his father was too old and too tired, Taro became the fisherman of the family. Everyone in the village knew Taro was a great fisherman, but he was also known for his kind heart. He would chat with the young, the old, and the lonely, bringing a little joy into their lives.

One cool evening, Taro came home after a long, discouraging day. He had only caught three small fish. "The fishing has been poor," he thought. Taro pulled his small boat onto the beach and started home. On his way, he heard some children laughing excitedly. He saw them tormenting a small sea turtle. "If you keep poking at that sea turtle, it'll die," called Taro. The children paid no attention and continued teasing the creature. Then Taro thought of a better way to deal with the mischievous children. "What if I trade you my fish for the turtle?" asked Taro. The children looked at each other, then looked at the sea turtle, and they cheered, "It's a deal!"

So Taro handed the children his day's catch in exchange for the turtle's safety. The children ran off into the distance, laughing

and chattering about their great bargain. Taro knelt down and gently picked up a small, shivering turtle. "I will return you to your home in the sea," said Taro. "I'm sure you will be much happier there." Taro walked to the edge of the water and carefully coaxed the turtle into the gentle waves. He waited until the turtle disappeared far in the distance, and then he headed home with an empty basket.

The next morning, as always, Taro rolled out to the open ocean. As he sat and waited for a fish to come, the soft waves splashed against the sides of his boat. It was very quiet and peaceful. Suddenly, he heard his name ring out in the ocean breeze. He looked around, but there were no other boats in sight. "Well, I must have heard the cry of a seagull," thought Taro, and he went back to his fishing. Again, he heard his name, this time clear as a bell. He looked around again. He saw a sea turtle swimming alongside his boat. "A sea turtle calling my name?" chuckled Taro.

"Yes, Taro," answered the sea turtle, surprising the lad even more. "Thank you for saving my life yesterday."

"Oh, it's you," said Taro. "You are very welcome."

Then the turtle asked Taro if he had ever seen the dragon palace. Taro shook his head and said, "Oh, I have heard many enchanting stories of this magnificent palace at the bottom of the sea, but I myself have never had the pleasure of visiting this wonderful place."

"Then I would like to take you there," said the turtle.

Taro returned to his fishing and said, "I'd love to go, but I haven't finished my work. Besides, I don't have the strength to swim that distance.

"Oh, you may ride upon my back," said the turtle, and at that moment, the turtle grew to an enormous size. "Now would you come with me," asked the turtle. Taro could not resist the invitation, so he climbed upon the sea turtle's back, and he held onto the animal's shell. Then they dove into the deep blue sea. Strangely enough, Taro didn't grow tired as he traveled through the depths of the ocean. They swam through fields of gold and seaweed until they reached a clearing. In the distance, a magnificent gate appeared. When the two travelers arrived, they could see a courtyard of colorful fish. The fish gave Taro a warm welcome and led them to a large hallway that was lined with golden columns so tall they seemed to touch the sky. The floors were tiled with shells more brilliant than the scales of a fish, and the walls were covered with coral, pearls, and of precious stones. Never before had this fisherman seen such beauty and elegance.

A lovely princess appeared. "Welcome to my father's palace, Urashima Taro. The sea turtle has told me of your kindness, and I'm so glad you have decided to come." Her voice echoed through the chambers like a melody. She led him to a large table covered with elegant trays of delicious foods.

"Such a marvelous feast for a mere fisherman," thought Taro. Court musicians filled the room with beautiful music. Taro spent many enchanted hours at the dragon palace. Each day brought new pleasures to behold, and every wish Taro ever had came true. He was so happy there, he forgot everything.

Three days slipped by before he even gave a thought to the home he left behind, his parents, or his life as a fisherman. One day, the princess led Taro to a large viewing room. On each wall was a window, and each looked out on the beautiful garden that surrounded the palace. "This is a timeless garden where the four seasons can be seen at once," said the princess.

Taro looked through the East window and saw spring. Cherry trees were in full bloom, and a fresh aroma filled the air. Through the South window, Taro saw the warmth of summer, a carpet of grass with lush green trees bearing fruit that was so ripe he could almost taste its sweetness. Looking through the West window, Taro could see the trees of autumn. The warm colored leaves tossed and floated against the sunset sky. Then a cold wind blew into the room, and Taro turned toward the North window. His heart fell, for the cold winter scene reminded him of his own village. A chill ran down his back, for now he realized how much he missed his life as a fisherman. He slowly turned to the princess and explained that his parents must be worried, and it was time to go home.

The princess began to weep and beg Taro to stay, but Taro shook his head in sorrow, for he knew he had already stayed much too long.

The princess handed him a shiny black lacquered box tied with a red silk cord. "Taro, you must take this box as a token, but please never open it, for it contains something very precious," Taro promised never to open the box and waved farewell as he left the palace. The turtle carried Taro back through the sea to the shore of his village.

Taro walked slowly along the same shore he had walked many times before, but something seemed different. The hills inshore were the same, but there were many new houses he had never seen before. He walked towards his home, but in its place, he found a strange new house. He ran to an old man who was sitting nearby and asked him, "Oji-san, what happened to the house of Urashima?"

"Oh, you must be a stranger," said the old man. "My grandfather told me the legend of the young Urashima Taro boy who was swallowed by the sea, but that was hundreds of years ago."

"That cannot be possible. I am Urashima Taro!" The old man looked at Taro in bewilderment. He shook his head, for he was too old and too tired to argue about such nonsense. Confused and frightened, Taro ran to the shore, for that was the only thing that did not change. He was comforted by the lonesome pounding of the surf. "Perhaps the sea turtle will return," Taro thought. He waited and waited, but the turtle did not appear. "There's no hope."

Then he remembered the black box. "Perhaps this will take me back to the palace." Although he had promised not to open it, he slowly untied the red silk cord and carefully lifted the lid. A strange cloud of mist drifted out and brushed against Taro's face, then floated away into the sea breeze. Bewildered, Taro looked into the empty box. Suddenly, his face grew wrinkled, his dark black hair turned snowy white, and his youthful body grew old. Now Taro understood: the box had contained his youth. Moments ago, Taro was a strong young man, but now he sat alone on the beach, a very old, old man.

The tale of "Urashima Taro" is a story with many different meanings. Some say the moral of the story is never to break promises. Others say the moral is that fortune and money do not always bring happiness, and that true happiness comes from the family, the home, and the heart. Still, other people say there is no moral at all to this story. It's just a story which will make you feel happy and make you feel sad.

"Urashima Taro" is one of many folktales from Japan. You can find others in your school and public libraries, like "Momotaro the Peach Boy" and "Kaguyahimi the Luminous Princess" and "Shadika Suzume the Tongue-cut Sparrow". Read and enjoy the folktales from Japan and from all over the world. Share a story with a friend so our tales will never end.